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Is There a Feminist Tradition on War and Peace?

Jean Bethke Elshtain

THERE IS NO SEPARATE feminist tradition on war and peace. A recent work on *Traditions of International Ethics* includes no chapter on a “feminist tradition.”¹ For good reason: each articulated feminist position represents either an evolution within or a break-out from a previous historic discourse. Thus one finds feminist Hobbesians and feminist pacifists, liberal internationalists, and nationalistic isolationists. Which feminist position a particular thinker or advocate endorses will depend upon the tradition in which her feminism is lodged or out of which it emerges. Although feminist antiwar pacifism (variously grounded) is perhaps the best known and most prevalent of feminist positions, it does not stand alone. In this chapter, I shall offer a sense of the landscape of feminist discourse, historically and currently, on matters of war and peace. To say that it is difficult to assess “a feminist tradition” in matters of war and peace is to understate. Do not expect a tidy picture. Despite the often doleful pleas of feminists for women to unite, women and feminism remain divided on every important war and peace question. There is no clear-cut “feminist way” to discuss how war and peace have been understood. There is, however, a rather rough-and-ready feminist outlook that serves as a backdrop to current controversies. I will begin there.

Feminism emerged in the West as one feature of liberalism, indebted to Enlightenment presuppositions and the doctrine of the “rights of man.” I refer, of course, to feminism as a self-conscious enterprise, an enterprise announced by the publication in 1792 of Mary Wollstonecraft’s *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman*. Wollstonecraft sought to extend the French Revolution’s proclamation of the rights of man to women. She insists that women must be active citizens if they are to pass civic virtue on to their young. She effaces the distinction between men and women, where bodily strength is concerned, by calling for identical educations for boys and girls. What would emerge from educational symmetry, she hoped, was a decisive strike against what she took to be Jean-Jacques Rousseau’s misidentification of virtue—his embrace of what I have called “armed civic virtue.” For Wollstonecraft, there is no honor in the soldier, past or present, for the vast majority of soldiers are a mass swept along by coercion and command. Thus a standing army is “incompatible with freedom.” She

condemns Rousseau for exalting “to demi-gods [those] who were scarcely human—the brutal Spartans, who, in defiance of justice and gratitude, sacrificed, in cold blood, the slaves who had shewn themselves heroes to rescue their oppressors.”² Yet, in general, she endorses many of the ends and aims of civic republicanism—civic virtue and autonomy first and foremost, shorn of its martial dimensions. But she nowhere addresses what the grounds, if any, for war might be. Nor does she spend any time exploring wartime conduct.

Wollstonecraft simply assumes a national identity, paying no attention to the violent manner in which the revolutionary French molded that identity by yanking young men out of their local identities, disciplining their bodies to armed purposes, scraping off the insignia of their particularity by the visible sign of putting diverse human elements into identical uniforms. A supporter of the Revolution, she does not engage the presiding revolutionary images. These included paintings of the militant Spartan Mother and of liberty as represented by Marianne, a young female militant with one breast bared.³ The civic republican world, for all its female icons, was strongly male-dominant. Wollstonecraft endorses this tradition but hopes that, somehow, if men and women receive the same education, a softening will follow. This tension—endorsing “the same” but expecting “the different”—is by no means limited to Mary Wollstonecraft; indeed, if there is a tradition of feminist thought on war and peace, one feature of it is an ongoing repetition of a fundamental ambivalence: should women “fight” men or join men in fighting? There is also a near-silence on the most salient war/peace issues as they emerged in the writings of Western theorists, moralists, and war-fighters: What is a justified war? What should or should not be done in fighting a war? What are the grounds for resistance to political authority, and what is permissible by way of resistance? What is most strikingly displayed, as one surveys the history and literature of feminism, is the continuing manifestation of an abiding (one is almost tempted to say, Ur-) ambivalence.

Mary Wollstonecraft inherited a tradition in which women were tied to diverse conceptions of war and peace. One, the historically grounded, legendary, and prototypical Spartan Mother, offers up the woman as a civic militant who bears children “that they might die for Sparta and this is what has come to pass for me.” She is one of the prefeminist exemplars who helps to frame later feminisms. For the Spartan Mother, war is the consequence of the existence of an external “other” who poses a threat to one’s city, civic republic, or polity. Her identity is entangled with war’s honor and the valor of husbands and sons. War is justified for patriotic reasons of state. Later civic republicans, like Rousseau, recalling the glories of Sparta, insisted that the potent love of mother country, the willingness to serve and protect her, would shrivel on the civic vine if mothers no longer fig-

ured overpoweringly in the affections and civic upbringing of their children. There are so many continuing evocations of the Spartan Mother tradition that it would take volumes to catalog all of them. This much, however, should be noted: for the Spartan Mother, any serious threat to civic freedom is a justified *causus belli*. I know of no systematic discussion in the Spartan Mother image, past or present, of the conduct of war. Presumably, war is hell, a sometimes necessary hell. Here Spartan Mothers would vary depending upon the traditions of their own society. No doubt the mother of historic Sparta and the mother of the United States during the Second World War would take different tacks on this matter, though even here I am not so sure. Eighty to eighty-five percent of Americans endorsed dropping the atomic bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki, with no significant gender difference at the time. Women were by no means exempt from a perfervid nigh-extinctionist rhetoric where the Japanese were concerned.

My claim is not that the Spartan Mother is a feminist exemplar but that she embodies a version of women's history in relation to war and peace with which all feminists must grapple. In her civic determination and fortitude, she shines with the sort of civic identity that many feminists were later to endorse as preeminent among the familial verities and loyalties. When the crunch comes, she sacrifices private loyalties to overriding public purposes. For the Spartan Mother, there is no presumption against war save on the level of a hope that her country's freedom will never be threatened, from within or without. The grounds for war, or for crushing the oppositional forces that appear to threaten the polity from within, are primarily those of security—for her family and her nation.

For contemporary feminists whose worldview begins with an inexorable division between men and women, the Spartan Mother can only represent a retrograde "male-dominated" perspective and force. Ironically, hard-line "realist" feminists, who believe men and women are ontologically akin to different species and are, as well, in a state of perpetual war, are often far more unrelenting in their views of the necessity for a "sex war" than Spartan Mothers ever were in defense of their country's wars. Yet such feminists see in the Spartan Mother's loyalty to her polity and her willingness to see young men die in its defense a false-consciousness that they disdain to admit into the category "feminist"—despite the fact that they, too, anticipate the triumph of "public" over "private" values. Also, to make this sort of dismissive move requires jettisoning much of a tradition that, historically, often shifts uneasily between Spartan Mother and Beautiful Soul poles. Because we are all historically shaped, such wholesale dismissal is never possible.

The second main female exemplar, the Beautiful Soul, enters history—or, perhaps better put, is secured within the history of the West—with the

triumph of Christianity, hence with a presumption against violence and a dream of a peaceable kingdom. For there is what I am tempted to call a “feminization” of ethics associated with Christianity. Finding in the “paths of peace” the most natural as well as the most desirable way of being, Christian pioneers exalted a pacific ontology. Violence must justify itself before the court of nonviolence. Over time, within this broad tradition, men were constituted as just Christian warriors, fighters, and defenders of righteous causes whose violence required (at least in principle) elaborate justification. Women, unevenly depending upon social location, became solidified into a culturally sanctioned vision of virtuous, nonviolent womanhood I call the “Beautiful Soul.” It is important to note here that, although the Christian pacifist and just war streams parted historically, they nonetheless remain tied genealogically. Both put violence on trial, placing the burden of proof on those who take up arms.

For the Beautiful Soul, this presumption plays out as a nigh-absolute interdiction on female violence coupled with a mingling of regret and resoluteness should her society embark on a course of war. If there is one dominant feminist tradition before the twentieth century, it lies in a politicized version of the Beautiful Soul (of which more below). Once again, the tale is by no means simple, but by the late nineteenth century, “absolute distinctions between men and women in regard to violence” had come to prevail.⁴ The female Beautiful Soul is pictured as frugal, self-sacrificing, and, at times, delicate. Although many women empowered themselves to think and to act according to this ideal of female virtue, the symbol slides easily into sentimentalism. To “preserve the purity of its heart,” writes Hegel, the Beautiful Soul must flee “from contact with the actual world.”⁵ In matters of war and peace, the female Beautiful Soul cannot put a stop to suffering, cannot effectively fight the mortal wounding of sons, brothers, husbands, fathers. She continues the long tradition of women as keepers of the flame of non-warlike values even as, in the nonpacifist versions of Beautiful Souldom, it is the woman on the home front who makes the war effort itself sustainable over time. It is important to note that, in times of war, the Beautiful Soul exemplar often merges with the Spartan Mother as women are identified, and identify themselves, as heroines of the home front and upholders of a more or less total *levée en masse* associated with French Revolutionary civic republicanism.

Nineteenth-century suffragists appropriated both Spartan Motherhood and Beautiful Souldom for their cause. Votes for women were justified on the grounds of ontological equality between the sexes on the one hand, *and* female difference on the other. Some suffragist supporters trafficked in such sentiments as: “For the Safety of the Nation to the Women Give the Vote/For the Hand that Rocks the Cradle Will Never Rock the Boat!” Here an argument for votes for women on the grounds of utility (“for the

safety of the nation”) and stability (“will never rock the boat”) prevails. Presumably, giving women the vote will not disturb the existing, and justified, habit of entrusting war/peace decisions to men. During America’s Civil War, the leading suffragists supported the war effort even as they condemned war. They chided men for having brought the country into war, yet praised the fervent and spontaneous patriotism war engenders—a reaction frequently repeated, most recently in the United States in the Persian Gulf War of 1991. Suffragists decried war’s terrible cost, yet celebrated and legitimized the many campaigns fought by women in sanitary commissions, as suppliers, nurses, buriers of the dead. Elizabeth Cady Stanton extolled the “multitude of delicate, refined women, unused to care and toil, thrown suddenly on their own resources” during the war, and she used this story of wartime loyalty and sacrifice as further ammunition in behalf of the suffrage effort once the war was concluded.⁶ Stanton supported the Civil War, but she also thundered against “male wars” in other contexts, proclaiming that a “new evangel of womanhood” would put a decisive end to chaos and destructiveness. Here are her words:

The male element is a destructive force, stern, selfish, aggrandizing, loving war, violence, conquest, acquisition, breeding in the material and moral world alike discord, disorder, disease and death. See what a record of blood and cruelty the pages of history reveal! Through what slavery and slaughter, and sacrifice, through what inquisitions and imprisonments, pains and persecutions, black codes and gloomy creeds, the soul of humanity has struggled for the centuries, while mercy has veiled her face and all hearts have been dead alike to love and hope! The male element has held high carnival thus far, it has fairly run riot from the beginning, overpowering the feminine element everywhere, crushing out the diviner qualities in human nature until we know but little of true manhood and womanhood, of the latter comparatively nothing, for it has scarce been recognized as a power until within the last century. . . . The need of this hour is not territory, gold mines, railroads, or specie payments, but a new evangel of womanhood, to exalt purity, virtue, morality, true religion, to lift man up into the higher realms of thought and action.⁷

This is a tall order. It reminds me of the sentiment so often inscribed by one’s friends in one’s senior yearbook (if you graduated high school in the late 1950s in the United States, as I did): “Stay as Sweet as You Are!”—an expression often coupled to admonitions to be successful in life. How the suffragists thought to pull this one off remains murky, but there is little doubt they did intend it. All the problems of war and peace would somehow melt away once the epiphany of the new society was attained. In the meantime: condemn war, either absolutely or strategically; condemn men, either in principle or provisionally; extol women, both for their wartime

loyalty and contribution—as Spartan Mothers—and for their general outlook and principled opposition to violence—as Beautiful Souls.

A similar fusion of disparate imperatives and identities emerged in the era of the First World War with one group of solid Spartan Mothers—like Britain’s famous (or infamous) “Little Mother,” who trashed all pacifists, male and female. The “Little Mother” wrote a letter, published in the London *Morning Post* in 1916, denouncing pacifists and whiners and declaring that she herself was delighted to send her son off to war—the “sacred trust of motherhood” demands no less, for “women are created for the purpose of giving life, and men to take it.”⁸ Less violently, one Mrs. F. S. Hallows in her 1918 book, *Mothers of Men and Militarism*, noted women’s equally “passionate love of mother-country. . . . Though we loathe slaughter we find that after men have done their best to kill and wound, women are ever ready to mend the broken bodies, soothe the dying, and weep over nameless graves!”⁹ The Connecticut Congress of Mothers issued a “Ten Commandments of Womanhood,” which called for Mothers to “Hearten Thy Men and Weep Not” and to “Keep Thou the Faith of Thy Mothers, for in the years of thy country’s sacrifice for Independence and Union they served valiantly and quailed not.”¹⁰

In this same era, thousands of politicized women who were suffragists agitated for their country’s entrance into the war and proclaimed themselves ready to serve. Women of the Triple Entente often justified the war on liberal internationalist grounds: the world will be safe only when democracy defeats autocracy. (This argument, a bit tricky to square with Romanov Russia’s alliance with the British and French democracies, is expressive nonetheless of the liberal internationalist view that the world will be safe only when democracy defeats autocracy, for only then will the breeding ground for war be vanquished.) In line with such patriotic identification and in the wider cause of destroying the breeding ground of political evil (autocracy, militarism), when the Women’s Emergency Corps was created in Britain, women queued up in long lines waiting for the doors to open so they could sign up. For such women, the war was becoming a crusade. In this era, thousands of politicized women agitated for peace and proclaimed themselves in opposition to the war on the grounds of a new internationalism and humanism that would one day trump particularistic national loyalties as well as “militarism,” a generic term for the evil of arms, armies, and war.

The feminist antiwar stance in the era of the First World War is perhaps best summed up in the notion that there is an “eternal opposition,” in Jane Addams’s words, between feminism and militarism. Women have been linked to peace campaigns at least since the Middle Ages, to antiwar sentiment since the Greeks: I have in mind *The Trojan Women*, for example,

although here, as always, things are tricky. It is well to recall that the maternal Hecuba, mourning the death of Andromache and Hector's son, her grandson, Astyanax, decries the latter's "wretched death"—he has been thrown from the top of the city wall of Troy by its conquerors—and adds, "You might have fallen fighting for your city," anticipating, with this line, an honorable Spartan Mother resolution.¹¹ The traditional distinction between peace women and war women made sharply visible a prewar division between militant suffragists (more prevalent in Britain than in the United States), who were prepared to use violent methods ("the argument of the thrown stone") to achieve their ends, and the greater number of women who were opposed to all forms of violence, including violence against property. With the war, the militant suffragists tended toward Spartan Motherhood of the most jingoistic sort; the antiviolence suffragists, in their most visible incarnation, surfaced as that uneasy amalgam of Spartan Motherhood and Beautiful Souldom noted above. But there was a third alternative—opposition to the war as a logical continuance of the suffrage campaign. To such advocates, this meant humanizing governments by extending the suffrage to women. Women peace activists who embraced this idea discovered the causes of war in the maladjustment of industrial relations and the failure to pacify states by extending the suffrage. For many, women's nonviolence was a logical extension of maternalism. For others, particularly those associated with a socialist vision, peace meant the day when the causes of war (capitalism, imperialism) had been eliminated and men as well as women could embrace this vision.

My aim here is not to recall a well-documented history but to make explicit the markers of social identity and structures of discourse deployed by antiwar feminists in the era of the First World War. A Women's Peace Party was formed. At its height in the United States there were 165 group memberships totaling some 40,000 women. The American party was one section of the Women's International Committee for Permanent Peace—the Kantian echoes are apt—which had branches in fifteen countries. Antiwar feminists, in line with what Michael Howard calls "the liberal conscience," pushed for continuous arbitration, for a negotiated peace short of total victory, and for a peace settlement shorn of vindictiveness. In this and other ways, feminists in this period located themselves within the larger frame of pacifist/just war discourse. Women peace campaigners promulgated internationalism as a worldwide concatenation of peace-loving peoples, especially of women, to bring into being the conditions for permanent peace. After the war, women were influential in pressing for the Kellogg-Briand Pact of 1928 declaring war illegal, and were on the National Committee on the Cause and Cure of War, which collected ten million signatures on a disarmament petition in 1932. Contemporary feminist and women's peace efforts look back to these and other instances of

female activism, much of it under a feminist imprimatur, as historic warrant for their own efforts. Beautiful Soul presumptions against violence are dominant in these and similar efforts: violence is always terrible; women are the special keepers of non-warlike values; war is the breakdown of a natural condition of harmony and equilibrium, realizable and restorable yet again once the various “enemies” of this humane condition and vision are bested.

This version of feminism emerges, as I have already indicated, primarily as a variant of liberal internationalism. But the hope remains that if women ran things, the things they ran would look much different and be much better (more peaceful) than at present. At this point, feminism turns into pacifism—a pacifism grounded less on a Christian nonviolent ethic than on an often essentialist argument for women’s inherent peacefulness. All the questions having to do with war and peace historically—What are the grounds for war? What grounds are justifiable and what are not? Are there limits to fighting a war, even a “good war”?—melt away if one assumes that once women take over, war itself will disappear. This is a very old idea, continually refurbished as feminist ideology. For example, one of the first discursive moments in the history of feminism (retrospectively constructed, for the author in question was not self-consciously feminist) is Christine de Pizan’s *The Book of the City of Ladies*. Three goddesses—Rectitude, Reason, and Justice—found the author’s city. Noteworthy in this “mirror of princes” utopia is the falling away of any nastiness, any dilemma that might implicate the Wise Princess in the perennial dilemma of “dirty hands.” Wars are dramatic by their absence in the City of Ladies. Christine repeats the story of the Amazons, noting their “delight in the vocation of arms” and their merciless policy of vengeance; they were women whose skills demonstrated that they were “fit for all tasks.”¹² Accepting Amazonian escapades as historic truth, Christine nonetheless denies this narrative of female ferocity and martial vigor any contemporary clout. Her own vision of the “lady” and the Wise Princess bars such appropriations.

Christine thus anticipates later humanists, liberals, and rationalists who shared her fondness for Rectitude, Reason, and Justice and found war irrational, stupid, wasteful, and atavistic. This, at least, is a principled version of feminist antimilitarism and antiwar activity, and it is one variant of liberal internationalism. The major difference, perhaps, is that feminists are less likely than historic internationalists to justify military intervention on humanitarian grounds, finding in the means a collision with preferred ends. This tendency toward “purism” also provides an escape from the problem of “dirty hands.” Women scholars and activists prepared to talk about the latter problem fall between the stools of contemporary feminist discourse on war and peace.

This brings me to the turbulent present in feminist thinking on war and

peace. To draw together this chapter's themes, I will concentrate on feminism's uncertain trumpet—and I say this not to condemn but to reinforce the picture of competing feminist viewpoints and to offer a reminder of their often contradictory endorsements. For from its inception, feminism has not quite known whether to fight men or to join them; whether to lament sex differences and deny their importance or to acknowledge and even celebrate such differences; whether to condemn all wars outright or to extol women's contributions to war efforts. At times feminists have done all of these things, with scant regard for consistency.¹³ Thus one finds “right to fight” feminists who are endorsed by integrationist feminism incarnated in the United States by the National Organization for Women; revolutionary Marxist feminism prepared to approve “Third World revolutionary struggles” as well as to sanction a teleology of violence (if necessary) as part of their own struggle against the bourgeois order; pacifist feminism, sanctified by a plethora of old and new efforts. At the antiwar end of the spectrum, military women become explicable only as “clones of the male model.” At the “right to fight” end, pacifist women are construed as “wimps” and regarded as antifeminist because they find women less capable of soldiering than men.

It is impossible to survey the whole of contemporary feminist discourse in a few pages; it is, however, possible to situate feminist arguments on questions of war and peace inside one of several frames. Interestingly, feminism reproduces many assumptions that structure the historic discourses of realism and just war, recreating prototypical characters and arguments. Contemporary feminism has its “Machiavellian moment” as well as its Beautiful Soul reiterations of just war and pacifist ideas. One aspect of feminist argumentation is its often totalizing character: women must wage a total war against every aspect of patriarchal society, or women must struggle for world peace, total disarmament, and the like. That is, for radical feminist “realists” who presume men and women are, and have been, in a perpetual state of war, “anything goes” to achieve the overthrow of patriarchy. For feminist pacifists, means must be limited and constrained—not just “anything goes,” but anything is possible, including perpetual peace, once the conditions for war have been eliminated.

This is how feminist “realism” of a separatist variety works: Separatists declare the very condition of humankind to be one of undeclared but total war between men and women. They endorse a Hobbesian social ontology and construe politics as a continuation of this war. They advise women to “fight dirty” and make generous use of military metaphors (Who is the Enemy? Where is he located? How can you best defeat him?). Politics becomes a paradigm case of Oppressor and Oppressed, and there is a lot of tough talk about the sex war and the need for women to take over the extant power structure, even to wear uniforms and carry guns, as the only

way to end their “colonization.”¹⁴ Others in this mode turn to the language of pathology and disease. Men are the carriers of a taint. They have a need to oppress women. The pathology must be destroyed, by taming men or eliminating them. This is an argument for revolutionary violence that can, at best, produce an uneasy truce in the sex war—unless the enemy has actually been eliminated, through either unconditional surrender or a policy of actually reducing the number of men in the human race.¹⁵ Women who are not “pawns of men” must be in charge of all the changes.

The following is a pretty standard summary of a hard-core feminist “realism” in the present situation—all-out war, an ontology of violence governing relations between all men and all women everywhere—coupled with an apocalyptic utopian insistence that women, naturally pacifistic, will one day rule in peace:

Why weren't we prepared for this?—the imminence of nuclear holocaust; the final silencing of life; the brutal extinction of the planet. . . . We have lived with violence so long. We have lived under the rule of the fathers so long. Violence and patriarchy: mirror images. An ethic of destruction as normative. Diminished love of life, a numbing to real events as the final consequence. We are not even prepared. . . . Wars are nothing short of rituals of organized killing presided over by men deemed “the best.” The fact is—they are. They have absorbed in the most complete way the violent character of their own ethos. . . . Women know and feel the lies that maintain nuclear technology because we have been lied to before. We are the victims of patriotic lies. . . . To end the state of war, to halt the momentum toward death, passion for life must flourish. Women are the bearers of lifeloving energy. Ours is the task of deepening that passion for life and separating from all that threatens life, all that diminishes life; becoming who we are as women.¹⁶

Oddly, the triumph of the Beautiful Soul is anticipated in these often remorseless narratives. The rhetoric of total war dominates; but, ultimately, the victims will vanquish their oppressors. More plausible versions of feminist realism and its Beautiful Soul variants include, first, the stance of the National Organization for Women and, by extension, all versions of feminism based on rights absolutism. NOW has argued (in an amicus brief in a case involving the constitutionality of the all-male draft) that military service is central to the concept of citizenship. It follows that if women are to gain first-class citizenship, they, too must have the right to fight. In some instances this is coupled with the hope that women will “humanize” the armed services. Equal-opportunity feminism, then, walks an uneasy line between a presumption against war and the insistence that women fight wars.

The grounds for war are not discussed in any systematic way save for a tendency to favor wars for “liberation” and to oppose American interven-

tion for almost any purpose, anywhere, at any time. This latter predisposition was strained during the Gulf War, where some 6 percent of the deployed American force were women. Replaying a familiar hand, a number of prominent feminist politicians and activists condemned the war as an overreaction (at best), yet used the war as an occasion to push for total abrogation of the few remaining statutory limits to women in combat for the American All-Volunteer Force. Unsurprisingly, many military women—especially reservists—told feminist activists to mind their own business: they did not want to fight. But others, primarily officers, often from military families themselves, were delighted at the opportunity to test their mettle.

My own favorite testimony along these lines is Major Rhonda Cornum's postwar ("as told to") memoir. Cornum, who was taken prisoner by the Iraqis when her helicopter crashed, writes of the fact that she didn't want "to go home without seeing action" for she was prepared to "go to war. . . . Fly and fight. I loved it."¹⁷ She had chosen to go to a military medical school rather than a civilian one (she is a flight surgeon), and she and her husband "feel the same way about the big things: duty, honor, country, loyalty. . . . [My daughter] would have thought that I was a wimp if I stayed home."¹⁸ She, for one, wasn't afraid of dying—much worse would be to dishonor her uniform and her country. This is a stance that feminist pacifists, whether Christian or the strategic sort whose pacifism comes and goes with the occasion, find well-nigh inexplicable. Cornum, needless to say, sees herself as a women's rights egalitarian.

For remember, emerging from the historic discourse surveyed above is a version of the Beautiful Soul grounded in a pacific, not a violent, ontology. Men may be oppressors, but the condition of society is not "war"; it is injustice to be fought by nonviolent means. Analysts in this mode insist that women do have insights to bring to bear on the public world. Women are located as moral educators and political actors. This discourse struggles to forge links between what Sara Ruddick has called "maternal thinking" and nonviolent theories of conflict without assuming that it is possible to translate, easily, maternal imperatives into a public good.¹⁹ This view differs from celebrations of a peaceful matriarchy. Its proponents recognize that people must grow up, must become citizens. A citizen is not guaranteed nurture but is sure, instead, to find disagreement and conflict short of war, save for truly extreme instances (Nazism, genocide). The pitfalls of this feminism are linked to its intrinsic strengths. By insisting that women are in and of the social world, its framers draw explicit attention to the context within which their subjects act. But this wider context is one that continues to bombard women and mothers with the formulation that "doing good" means "being nice." Thus, even as stereotypical maternalism exerts pressure to sentimentalize, it is repudiated by competing feminisms that find in any evocation of "maternal thinking" a trap and a delusion.

In her book *Is the Future Female?* Lynne Segal finds much to praise and to challenge in contemporary evocations of “maternal thinking” tied to a wider set of hopes for peaceful arbitration of disputes. Those who evoke this hope (she includes Ruddick and Elshtain in this company) reject the biological reductionism of many eco-feminists and feminist pacifists (like the late Petra Kelly or Dr. Helen Caldicott, for example, who make much of wombs, harmony, inner peace, and so on). But the maternalist view is compatible, Segal argues, with many other positions—both radical and conservative. Unsurprisingly, she finds that real flesh-and-blood women (the majority!) more often than not express patriotism as well as “humanitarian revulsion from war.” Her case rests on a series of interviews with women who wire up weapons for the big arms industry (notice the Spartan Mother imagery lurking in the statement):

Our attitude [says one such woman] was that although it was unfortunate we were involved [in the Falklands War, in this case], once it was upon us we had to get on and do everything to back our boys. People were very willing to work overtime and do whatever was necessary, whether you’ve got a son involved or not, when it’s the English, it’s your boys, isn’t it? I mean it could be your boy next time.²⁰

I am reluctant to conclude on such an uncertain note. But it is one that aptly reflects the vagaries of the many “feminist” traditions in the matter of war and peace. Perhaps a story will help the reader to better appreciate my frustration. When I was putting together a collection on just war theory, I searched high and low for articles by feminists—indeed, by female scholars—lodged securely in the just war tradition and exploring either feminism or war and peace more generally inside that framework. I turned up almost nothing. Perhaps because women have not been history’s war fighters, it has been easier for them—and feminists, too—to treat the matter in one of two often extreme ways: either everything is war and ordinary life is construed as a state of “supreme emergency” with men trying, quite literally, to kill and coerce women, or the concrete realities and limits of the world in which we live are overcome discursively by working toward and arguing in behalf of some Kantian (or more feminized) version of perpetual peace. (I refer, of course, to feminists who are not specifically Christian or ethical pacifists. To the extent they are, their feminism seems less dominant than their pacifism, and that is explored by Ted Koontz in his chapter.)

At this point, I would go in the direction of a version of Christian realism in the Niebuhrian tradition. Here’s why: I cling to no shibboleth that women, if drafted in large numbers, would somehow transform the military and war-fighting. We are not well served by the abstract language of civic obligation and rights here. One example would be the ways in which theories of justice modeled on macroeconomics, if given a feminist turn

and applied internationally, often lead to the imposition on other societies of a vision of justice and a norm of gender relations that is distinctly Western, even North American. I recall the unsettling experience of hearing a feminist scholar, herself indebted to such models of justice, justifying the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan on the grounds that the Afghans were a patriarchal, sexist people—somehow the Soviets would bring them up to speed! Such abstract conceptions of justice suggest that we will have a just society or a just international order only when messy human life and lives conform to a more or less formal model, one that is by definition a static snapshot rather than a theory supple enough to come to grips both with the ebb and flow of human affairs and with differences, sexual, political, and cultural. If anything, the post-Cold War world should disabuse us of the idea that people (women included) will, when the crunch comes, prove more devoted to an abstract ideal of some future perfect society than to defending their own very specific cultures and “places”—often coupled with a rough-and-ready notion of human rights as a minimal standard, a set of restrictions on what governments or opponents or enemies should do to their own or other people.

The realism toward which I gesture has more in common with just war thinking than it does with Hobbesianism or Machiavellianism. I call my prototypical civic character a “chastened patriot,” one who modulates the rhetoric of high patriotism (and hence repudiates the Spartan Mother as a dominant identity), keeping alive the distancing voice of ironic recognition of how patriotism can shade into the excesses of nationalism, recognition of the fact that patriotism in the form of armed civic virtue is a dangerous chimera. The chastened patriot is both committed and detached: enough apart so that he or she can be reflective about civic ties and loyalties, cherishing many loyalties rather than one alone. This version of civic identity is not only compatible with but helps to sustain a “minimalist universalism” without falling into the abstract, juridical naiveté of so much liberal internationalism. How such a character—who might or might not be a feminist, although a feminist variant would be apt—sorts out conceptions of war and peace would be complex, drawing upon the many traditions and currents that have shaped and continue to shape Western life and thought.

NOTES

1. Terry Nardin and David R. Mapel, *Traditions of International Ethics* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992).

2. Mary Wollstonecraft, *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (New York: W. W. Norton, 1967), 75.

3. In *Women and War* (New York: Basic Books, 1987), I introduce several prototypes exemplifying particular perspectives. The Spartan Mother—the woman who

places the civic above the private and is prepared (even eager) to sacrifice her sons on the altar of civic necessity—is one. The Just Warrior and the Beautiful Soul are the other dominant collective representations in the Western story of war and peace.

4. Natalie Zemon Davis, “Men, Women, and Violence: Some Reflections on Equality,” *Smith Alumnae Quarterly* (Apr. 1975), 15.

5. G.W.F. Hegel, *The Phenomenology of Spirit*, trans. A. V. Miller (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1977), 399–400.

6. Elizabeth Cady Stanton, Susan B. Anthony, and Matilda Joslyn Gage, eds., *History of Woman Suffrage*, vol. 2 (Rochester, NY: Charles Mann, 1887), 1–2.

7. Stanton et al., *History of Woman Suffrage*, 2: 785.

8. For a full discussion, see Elshtain, *Women and War*, 192–93.

9. *Mothers of Men and Militarism* (London: Headley Brothers, Bishopsgate, 1918), 24–25.

10. As cited in Elshtain, *Women and War*, 147.

11. David Grene and Richmond Lattimore, eds., *Greek Tragedies*, vol. 2 (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1960), 272, 288.

12. Christine de Pizan, *A Book of the City of Ladies*, trans. Earl Jeffrey Richards (New York: Persea Books, 1982), 40–42.

13. In discussing contemporary feminism, I draw freely on *Women and War*.

14. These quotations are from “early” (1970s) feminist texts, but the presumptions are widely shared, as I note, to the present moment. The sources are Ti-Grace Atkinson, “Theories of Radical Feminism,” in Shulamith Firestone, ed., *Notes from the Second Year: Women’s Liberation* (n.p., 1970), 37, and Susan Brownmiller, *Against Our Will: Men, Women and Rape* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1975), 388.

15. “The proportion of men must be reduced to and maintained at approximately 10% of the human race.” Sally Miller Gerheart, “The Future—If There Is One—Is Female,” in Pam McAllister, ed., *Reweaving the Web of Life* (Philadelphia: New Society Publishers, 1982), 266–84.

16. Barbara Zanotti, “Patriarchy: A State of War,” in McAllister, *Reweaving*, 16–19.

17. Rhonda Cornum (as told to Peter Copeland), *She Went to War* (Novato, CA: Presidio Press, 1992), 4.

18. Cornum, *She Went to War*, 21.

19. See Ruddick’s essays, “Maternal Thinking” and “Preservative Love and Military Destruction,” in Joyce Trebilcock, ed., *Mothering: Essays in Feminist Theory* (Totowa, NJ: Rowman and Allanheld, 1983), 213–30 and 231–62 respectively. See also “The Rationality of Care,” in Jean Bethke Elshtain and Sheila Tobias, eds., *Women, Militarism and War* (Totowa, NJ: Rowman and Littlefield, 1990), 229–54.

20. *Is the Future Female?* (London: Virago Press, 1987), 198.